



Lesson 5: Build a Professional Presence Beyond LinkedIn

What This Lesson Is About

LinkedIn has an age minimum, and even if you're old enough, you might not have it set up yet — and that's completely fine. A real professional presence doesn't depend on one platform. It depends on whether the people who matter (teachers, mentors, competition judges, internship coordinators, scholarship reviewers, future employers) can find real, credible proof of what you can do.

This lesson's core idea: a strong portfolio-first presence — built on your Course 16 site plus a few other channels — is not a smaller or "junior" version of a professional presence. It is equally credible. A live project someone can actually see and try tells an evaluator more than a network profile ever could.

Why This Matters

Adults who evaluate teenagers are not expecting a polished LinkedIn network. They're expecting to see specific, real, checkable evidence: a project you built, a competition you entered, a showcase you were part of, growth they can trace over time. Every student can build that, starting today, regardless of age or platform access.

Presence Channels Beyond LinkedIn

Channel	What it is	Why it builds credibility
Portfolio site (your Course 16 site)	A site you fully control, showing your projects, skills, and how to reach you	Direct evidence of real work — the single most important channel you own
Content/notes section	A simple, ongoing log on your portfolio site — short updates about what you're building and learning	Shows growth over time and recent activity, not a one-time snapshot
School-sanctioned showcases & competitions	Science fairs, hackathons, robotics leagues, app challenges, art/writing contests, class exhibitions	Third-party recognition — someone outside you vouched for the work
Community project boards	Places built for sharing specific kinds of work: GitHub for code, Behance for design, a class-wide showcase page or Padlet	Discoverability within a community of people who understand the work
Referral networks	Teacher recommendations, school mentorship programs, alumni-to-student introduction systems	Personal vouching from someone with credibility of their own

You don't need every channel. You need a **primary channel** (usually your portfolio site) plus **one or two supporting channels** that reinforce it.

Worked Example: Alex T., age 15

Alex is building a presence around web development, without LinkedIn.

- **Portfolio site:** alext.lumexa.dev — home page with a one-line bio, a projects page with two real sites Alex built (a chess-timer app and a local animal shelter's volunteer sign-up page), each with a short write-up of the problem solved and tools used.
- **Content/notes section:** Every two weeks, a short entry like *"Sept 1: Rebuilt the shelter sign-up form so it works on phones. Took a while to figure out why the layout broke on small screens — turned out to be a missing CSS unit."*
- **School showcase:** The shelter sign-up project was entered in Alex's school's community-impact tech fair and won "Most Useful Project."
- **Community project board:** Both projects are uploaded to Alex's class GitHub organization, where classmates and teachers can browse them.

Nowhere in this presence does Alex need LinkedIn. An evaluator looking at this sees real projects, visible growth, and outside recognition — everything a strong presence requires.

Step-by-Step Activity

1. **Open your Course 16 portfolio site.** Check that it has: a bio, at least one real project with a description, and a way to contact you.
2. **Add or update your content/notes section.** Write two short entries (2–4 sentences each) about work you've actually done. Use this starter if you're stuck: *"This week I worked on . **The hardest part was** . Next I want to try ____."*
3. **Pick two channels beyond your primary one.** Look at the Presence Channels Map above. Choose one channel to strengthen this month (for example: submit a project to a school showcase, upload a project to a community board, or ask a teacher about a referral/mentorship program).
4. **Write one concrete next action for each channel you picked,** with a realistic date (this week or this month — not "eventually").
5. **Bring your updated site and your two next actions to class** for discussion and instructor review.

Key Terms

- **Channel:** Any specific place or way that people can discover your work and skills — a website, a showcase, a competition, a community board.
- **Credibility:** How trustworthy your presence is to someone evaluating it — built through real evidence, specificity, and outside recognition, not through how many platforms you're on.

- **Discoverability:** How easy it is for the right person to actually find your work — a clear link, a searchable name, a listed project — regardless of which platform hosts it.

Knowledge Checks

1. True or False: A professional presence is not real or complete unless it includes a LinkedIn profile.
2. Give one reason a live, working project on a portfolio site can be *more* convincing to an evaluator than a LinkedIn profile alone.
3. Name two presence channels, other than a portfolio site, that are open to students of any age.
4. What is the purpose of a content/notes section on a portfolio site?
5. Why does third-party recognition (like a competition placement or school showcase) strengthen credibility more than a self-written claim alone?

Reflection Prompts

1. Which of your current presence channels feels strongest right now, and why?
2. If an internship coordinator or college admissions reader looked only at your portfolio site today, what would they learn about you — and what's missing?
3. What is one specific, dated action you're committing to this week to strengthen a presence channel beyond your portfolio site?

Submission Instructions

Submit the following to your instructor by the start of the next lesson: - The link to your updated portfolio site (with at least 2 content/notes entries added). - Your completed Worksheet ("Presence Beyond LinkedIn"), including your channel-selection table and reflection. - Come prepared to briefly share (1–2 sentences) the one channel you're strengthening this month.